he will give? Note that the soldier will also be entitled to 30 days of annual and another 30 days of casual leave in a year. Which means the effective service of an Agniveer soldier could well be just about two years after basic and professional training is done, counting the leave entitlements.

The Agnipath scheme is rooted in the belief that the Indian army, at 1.4 million, is too big. Calls for reducing manpower have not worked, hence the forced surgery. In the past two years, recruitment, which used to average 65,000 per year, has been nil. On the other hand, 50,000 personnel have retired annually as scheduled. The reduced intake will begin to impact immediately. Reduced training and the too-quick turnover of personnel brought on by Agnipath cannot but affect the quality of personnel.

Presumably, soon the Indian military will consist of 75 per cent Agniveers and 25 per cent career professionals. This is not unlike the profiles of other militaries that use conscription for the purpose. But they had to adopt this profile out of compulsion. India has no dearth of people wanting to join the armed forces. There may have been other ways to achieve the same goal, such as reducing the size of the army from 1.4 million to, say, 850,000 and giving a one-time VRS to those being axed. This is the technique the Chinese PLA adopted in 2018, when it slashed 300,000 troops. Another way could have been to institute a seven-year service for the Agniveers which would have given the army a fair shot at training them to do the job for a reasonable period of five years.

There are many loose ends in the Agnipath scheme and many veterans express fears for the future. Traditions in the military are not just about show, but a means of cementing a fighting doctrine and expressing elan. Change is important, but there is a big danger of the military losing its balance from reforms that may not have been carefully considered for its ultimate impact. ■

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JHARKHAND

CHASING THE TRIBAL VOTE

By Amitabh Srivastava

SOMNATH SEN



SAFFRON TRIBE (From L) BJP state chief Deepak Prakash and J.P. Nadda at the Birsa Munda Vishwas rally, June 5

With Chief Minister Hemant Soren backed into a corner amidst a rash of legal challenges, the opposition BJP is pushing to reclaim the tribal support it had once assiduously built in Jharkhand. Targeting a tribal CM is tricky business, so it has resorted to do it by evoking a legendary tribal hero—as BJP president J.P. Nadda did on June 5 at the 'Dharti Aba Birsa Munda Vishwas' rally in Ranchi. Here, Nadda described CM Soren as a "symbol of corruption" who misled the tribals and dwelt on how the BJP has empowered them. For good measure, he also cited the eight Rajya Sabha MPs, 190 MLAs and two governors the party has from Scheduled Tribe communities.

The timing of the tribal push is significant. It comes just as the Election Commission (EC) has served a disqualification notice to Soren under the Representation of People's Act and the Jharkhand High Court has allowed two PILs regarding alleged irregularities in mining leases and dealings in shell companies said to be operated by his family members.

Soren carries some cachet as the son of Jharkhand Mukti Morcha co-founder Shibu Soren, whose movement finally birthed Jharkhand as a separate state, hived off from Bihar, on Birsa Munda's birthday in November 2000. Over 25 per cent of Jharkhand's population is tribal; 28 of its 81 assembly seats are reserved for STs. The BJP's loss in the 2019 polls is mainly credited to the JMM (19)-Congress (6) combine taking 25 of these seats.

The BJP realises Adivasi votes are crucial, so has got a number of tribal leaders back in play in Jharkhand

State BJP chief Dipak Prakash says "exposing" Soren and his party is a priority for the party. "The Adivasis have realised Hemant won a majority on the back of 'Jal, Jungle, Zameen' welfarist slogans but is just filling the coffers of his family members."

Jharkhand is home to four major tribal groups—Santhal, Munda, Ho and Oraon. The BJP has a grip on Munda votes, owing to the impact of saffron leaders like Karia Munda and ex-CM Arjun Munda; the JMM footprint is more among Soren's own Santhal group; the Congress has some backing among the Ho and Oraon. The BJP has learned from its 2019 defeat. Former CM Raghubar Das, a non-tribal, has taken a backseat and Arjun Munda, presently Union minister of tribal affairs, is more visible than ever in the state. The party also re-inducted another tribal ex-CM, Babulal Marandi, within two months of its electoral loss. The BJP clearly wants to win back the favour of the Adivasis. ■